

David Hume

Section 2: Of the Origin of Ideas

Everyone will readily allow that there is a considerable difference between the perceptions of the mind when a man feels the pain of excessive heat or the pleasure of moderate warmth, and when he afterwards recalls this sensation in his memory or anticipates it in his imagination. Memory and imagination may mimic or copy the perceptions of the senses, but they can never reach the force and vivacity of the original perception. Even at their utmost vigor, the most we can say is that they represent their object in so lively a manner that we could almost say we feel or see it. Except when the mind is disordered by disease or madness, memory and imagination can never be so lively as to make these perceptions indistinguishable from those we have through seeing or feeling. The most lively thought is still duller than the faintest sensation.

A similar distinction applies to all other perceptions of the mind. A fit of real anger is very different from merely thinking of that emotion. If you tell me that someone is in love, I understand your meaning and form a correct conception of his state, but I never mistake that conception for the actual tumults and agitations of love! When we reflect on our past sensations and emotions, our thought is a faithful mirror that copies its objects, but it does so in colors that are faint and washed-out compared with those in which our original perceptions were clothed. To distinguish between them requires neither careful thought nor philosophical skill.

We can therefore divide the perceptions of the mind into two classes, distinguished by their different degrees of force and vivacity. The less forceful and lively are commonly called "thoughts" or "ideas." The other class has no name in our language or in most others, probably because, unless we are doing philosophy, we have no need for a general label for them. Let us, then, take the liberty of calling them "impressions," using the word in a sense somewhat different from the usual one. By the term "impression," I mean all our more lively perceptions, when we hear, see, feel, love, hate, desire, or will. These are to be distinguished from ideas, which are the less lively perceptions of which we are conscious when we reflect upon our impressions.

At first glance, human thought might seem utterly unrestrained: it not only escapes all human power and authority (as when a pauper thinks of becoming rich overnight, or an ordinary citizen imagines being a king), but is not even confined within the boundaries of nature and reality. For the imagination, it is as easy to create monsters and join incongruous shapes and appearances as it is to think of the most natural and familiar objects. And while our body is confined to crawling upon the surface of one planet, thought can instantly transport us to the most distant regions of the universe—or even beyond. What has never been seen or heard may yet be conceived; nothing is beyond the power of thought, except what implies an absolute contradiction.

Yet, although our thought seems so free, a closer examination shows that it is really confined within very narrow limits, and that all this creative power of the mind amounts to no more than the faculty of compounding, transposing, augmenting, or diminishing the materials provided to us by the senses and experience. When we think of a golden mountain, we merely join two consistent ideas—that of gold and that of a mountain—both of which we already knew. We can conceive of a virtuous horse, because our own feelings enable us to form a

conception of virtue, and we can unite this with the shape of a horse, an animal familiar to us. In short, all the materials of thinking are derived either from our outward senses or from our inward feelings; all the mind and will can do is mix and combine these materials. Expressed in philosophical terms: all our ideas or more feeble perceptions are copies of our impressions or more lively perceptions.

To prove this, I shall present two arguments which, I hope, will be sufficient:

(1) When we analyze our thoughts or ideas—however complex or sublime they may be—we always find that they resolve into simple ideas copied from some earlier sensation or feeling. Even ideas that seem at first glance most distant from this origin turn out, upon closer examination, to be derived from it. The idea of God—meaning an infinitely intelligent, wise, and good Being—arises from reflecting on the operations of our own minds and augmenting those qualities of goodness and wisdom without limit. However far we carry this inquiry, we shall always find that every idea we examine is copied from a similar impression. Those who claim that this is not universally true, and that there are exceptions, have only one way to refute it—which, if they are right, ought to be easy. That is simply to produce an idea that they believe is not derived from this source. It will then be up to me to defend the doctrine; that is, to point out the impression or lively perception corresponding to the idea they produce.

(2) If a person cannot experience a certain kind of sensation because of a defect in the eyes or ears, they can never have the ideas corresponding to that sensation. A blind man can form no notion of colors; a deaf man can form no notion of sounds. If these individuals are cured of their blindness or deafness, the sensations can reach them, and the ideas will follow; then they find no difficulty in conceiving those objects. The same holds true for anyone who has never experienced a particular sensation: a Laplander or a Negro has no idea of the taste of wine. The same is true of inward feelings. It is very rare for a person never to have felt a particular human passion or emotion, or to be entirely incapable of it; but such instances do occur in the sphere of emotions as well, though to a lesser degree. A mild-tempered person can form no idea of resolved revenge or cruelty; a selfish person cannot easily grasp the heights of friendship and generosity. It is readily granted that non-human beings may possess many senses of which we have no conception, because those ideas have never been conveyed to us through the only channel by which they can enter the mind—namely, actual sensation and feeling.

(There is, however, one contradictory phenomenon which may prove that it is not absolutely impossible for ideas to arise independently of their corresponding impressions. It will readily be granted that the various distinct ideas of color that enter by the eye (and the various ideas of sound that enter by the ear) are really different from one another, though resembling in certain respects. If this is true of different colors, it must be equally true of the different shades of the same color; that is, each shade produces a distinct idea, independent of the rest. (We could arrange a continuous sequence of shades from red to green, each passing imperceptibly into its neighbor. If contiguous shades in the series were not distinct, then red would not differ from green, which is absurd.) Now suppose a person with normal vision has become perfectly acquainted with colors of all kinds, except for one particular shade of blue which he happens never to have encountered. Let all the other shades of blue, descending gradually from the darkest to the lightest, be placed before him: he will immediately perceive a blank where that missing shade ought to be. That is, he will recognize that the distance in quality between these adjacent shades is greater than between any of the other pairs. Can he, then, through his imagination, supply this deficiency? That is, can he raise up in his mind the

idea of that particular shade, even though it was never conveyed to him by his senses? Most people will believe that he can. This seems to show that simple ideas are not always, in every instance, derived from the corresponding impressions. Yet this instance is so singular that it scarcely deserves our notice, and does not alone furnish sufficient reason for altering our general maxim.)

Here, therefore, is a proposition that not only seems simple and intelligible in itself, but, if properly applied, can serve to demolish the reign of all absurd metaphysical jargon and render every dispute equally intelligible. There are three difficulties that complicate these metaphysical disputes:

- **(1)** All ideas, especially abstract ones, are naturally faint and obscure, so that the mind holds only a slender grasp on them.
- **(2)** Ideas are apt to be confounded with other resembling ideas.
- **(3)** When we have frequently used a word, we are prone to imagine that it is attached to a determinate idea, even when we have no distinct meaning connected with it.

By contrast:

- **(1)** All our impressions—that is, all sensations, whether outward or inward—are strong and vivid.
- **(2)** The boundaries between them are more strictly determined.
- **(3)** It is far harder to fall into error or mistake concerning them.

Therefore, when we suspect that a philosophical term is employed without any meaning or idea (as is all too frequent), we need only inquire: *From what impression is that supposed idea derived?* If no impression can be pointed out, our suspicion is confirmed—that is, the term is devoid of meaning because it carries no idea behind it. By bringing ideas into so clear a light, we may reasonably hope to remove all dispute concerning their existence and their nature.¹

¹ Footnote

Those philosophers who deny the existence of innate ideas probably intended only that all ideas are copies of our impressions; yet the terms they used to express this opinion were neither chosen with sufficient care nor defined with sufficient precision to prevent misunderstandings regarding their doctrine. What is meant by "innate"? If it means "natural," all perceptions and ideas of the mind must be admitted to be natural or innate in every sense, whether the term is opposed to what is uncommon, artificial, or miraculous. If by "innate" is meant "coeval with our birth," the dispute seems frivolous; it is hardly worth inquiring when thinking begins—whether before, at, or after our birth. Again, Locke and others appear to use the word "idea" loosely, taking it to stand for any of our perceptions, sensations, and passions. What would it mean to say that self-love, resentment of injuries, or sexual passion are not innate?!

Yet if we take the words "impressions" and "ideas" in the sense explained above, and understand "innate" as meaning what is original or not copied from any previous perception, we may readily assert: all our impressions are innate, and none of our ideas are innate. Frankly, I think Locke was misled into this question by the Schoolmen, who used ambiguous terms to drag out their disputes to tedious lengths without ever touching the true heart of the matter. The same ambiguity and circumlocution appear in many of that great philosopher's reasonings on this and various other subjects.

Section 3: Of the Association of Ideas

The thoughts or ideas of the mind are evidently connected together in a certain manner: in memory and imagination, one idea clearly introduces another in a regular order. This is so apparent in our more serious thinking or conversation that any particular thought that breaks into the regular sequence is immediately noticed and rejected because it is irrelevant. Even in our wildest daydreams and nighttime fantasies, a little attention will show that the imagination does not run completely at random, but that the ideas follow one another with a degree of coherence. If the loosest and freest conversation were written down, something would immediately be seen to connect it through all its transitions. Even where that connection is not obvious, the person who broke the thread of conversation can point out a regular chain of thoughts that had gradually led them away from the subject. It is also remarkable that the compound ideas signified by words in one language are usually nearly identical to the compound ideas signified by words in another, even where the languages have had no influence on each other. This is certain proof that the simple ideas comprehended in compound ones are bound together by a universal principle that exerts an equal influence on all mankind.

That different ideas are connected together is too obvious to escape observation; yet I have not found any philosopher who has attempted to enumerate or classify all the principles of association—a subject that surely seems worthy of curiosity. To me, there appear to be only three principles of connection among ideas:

- **Resemblance**

- **Contiguity** in time or place
- **Cause or Effect**

There will scarcely be much doubt that our ideas are connected by these principles. A picture naturally directs our thoughts to the original object represented; the mention of one room in a building introduces comments or inquiries concerning the others; and when we think of a wound, we can scarcely help reflecting on the pain that follows it. But that these three are the only principles of association among ideas may be difficult to prove to the satisfaction of the reader, or even to my own satisfaction. All we can do is examine a great variety of instances where ideas are associated, identify the connective principle in each case, and gradually arrive at a truly general account of the phenomenon.² The more instances we examine and the more care we take, the greater assurance we can acquire that our enumeration of the principles of association is complete.

Section 4: Sceptical Doubts concerning the Operations of the Understanding

Part 1

All the objects of human reason or inquiry may naturally be divided into two kinds: *Relations of Ideas* and *Matters of Fact*.

The first kind includes Geometry, Algebra, and Arithmetic, and every affirmation which is either intuitively or demonstratively certain. For instance, that the square of the hypotenuse is equal to the sum of the squares of the other two sides expresses a relation between these figures. That three times five is equal to half of thirty expresses a relation between these numbers. Propositions of this kind are discoverable by the mere operation of thought, without dependence on anything actually existing anywhere in the universe. Though there were never a circle or triangle in nature, the truths demonstrated by Euclid would forever retain their certainty and self-evidence.

Matters of fact, the second kind of objects of human reason, are not ascertained in the same manner; nor is our evidence of their truth of the same nature with the former. The contrary of every matter of fact is still possible, because it can never imply a contradiction, and is conceived by the mind with the same facility and distinctness as if it perfectly corresponded with reality. That the sun will not rise tomorrow is no less intelligible a proposition, and implies no more contradiction, than the affirmation that it will rise. We should in vain, therefore, attempt to demonstrate its falsehood by abstract reasoning. Were it demonstratively false, it would imply a contradiction and could never be distinctly conceived by the mind.

It may, therefore, be a subject worthy of curiosity to inquire: What is the nature of that evidence which assures us of any real existence and matter of fact, beyond the present testimony of our senses or the records of our memory? It is remarkable that this question has been little explored by philosophers, ancient or modern; hence, in conducting this inquiry, we must tread an untrodden path without a guide—a circumstance that may serve as an excuse for any errors or doubts that may arise. Such doubts may even prove advantageous by exciting curiosity, encouraging deeper inquiry, and destroying that unwarranted, unexamined

confidence in received opinions which is the bane of all sound reasoning and free investigation. To discover defects in common philosophical views need not discourage us, but may rather incite us to seek something more complete and satisfying than what has hitherto been offered.

All reasonings concerning matter of fact seem to be founded on the relation of *Cause and Effect*. By means of that relation alone can we go beyond the evidence of our memory and senses. If you ask someone why they believe any matter of fact which is absent—for example, that their friend is in France—they would give you a reason; and this reason would be some other fact, such as having received a letter from them or knowing their prior resolution to travel there. A man finding a watch or any other machine on a desert island would conclude that there had once been men on that island. All our reasonings concerning fact are of the same nature. And here it is constantly supposed that there is a connection between the present fact and that which is inferred from it. Were there nothing to bind them together, the inference would be entirely precarious. Hearing an articulate voice and rational discourse in the dark assures us of the presence of some person. Why? Because these are the effects of the human organism and closely connected with it. If we anatomize all other reasonings of this nature, we shall find that they are resolved into the relation of cause and effect, and that this relation is either near or remote, direct or collateral. Thus, when we see light and infer heat, the two are not causes of each other, but collateral effects of a common cause—fire.

If we would satisfy ourselves, therefore, concerning the nature of that evidence which assures us of matters of fact, we must inquire how we arrive at the knowledge of cause and effect.

I shall venture to affirm, as a general proposition admitting of no exception, that the knowledge of this relation is not, in any instance, attained by reasonings *a priori*, but arises entirely from experience, when we find that particular objects are constantly conjoined with each other. Let an object be presented to a man of ever so strong natural reason and abilities; if that object be altogether new to him, he will not be able, by the most accurate examination of its sensible qualities, to discover any of its causes or effects. Adam, even if we suppose his rational faculties to be completely perfect from the very beginning, could not have inferred from the fluidity and transparency of water that it would suffocate him, or from the light and warmth of fire that it would consume him. No object ever discovers, by the qualities which appear to the senses, either the causes that produced it or the effects that will arise from it; nor can our reason, unassisted by experience, ever draw any inference concerning real existence and matter of fact.

This proposition—that causes and effects are discoverable not by reason, but by experience—is readily admitted:

- (1) In cases where we remember that the objects were once entirely unknown to us, because we recall our total inability at that time to foresee their operations. Present two smooth pieces of marble to a man with no knowledge of natural philosophy; he will never discover that they will adhere together in such a manner as to require great force to separate them directly, while offering very little resistance to a lateral slide.

- (2) In events that bear little analogy to the common course of nature, which are universally acknowledged to be known solely by experience; no one...

It may be said that, from a number of uniform experiences, we infer a connection between the sensible qualities and the secret powers; but this is merely stating the same difficulty in different words. We must still ask what process of argument this inference is founded upon. Where is the intermediate step, the mediating ideas, that join propositions so widely different? It is agreed that the color, consistency, and other sensible qualities of bread have no inherent connection with secret powers of nourishment and support. If they did, we could infer these secret powers upon our first encounter with those qualities, without any long prior experience; but this contradicts the belief of all philosophers as well as plain matters of fact.

Let us begin by considering our state of natural ignorance—that is, the condition in which we know nothing of the powers and operations of things. How does experience remove this ignorance? All it does is show us that particular, similar objects produce similar effects; it teaches us that these particular objects, at those particular times, were endowed with such and such powers. When a new object appears with similar sensible qualities, we expect similar powers and effects. For example, we expect that something having the color and consistency of bread will nourish us. But this is certainly a step taken by the mind that requires explanation.

When a man says, "I have found in all past instances such sensible qualities conjoined with such secret powers," and then goes on to say, "Similar sensible qualities will always be conjoined with similar secret powers," he is not merely repeating himself; these propositions are by no means the same.

You may say that the second proposition is inferred from the first; but it must be admitted that this inference is not intuitive (that is, its validity cannot be seen at a glance), nor is it demonstrative. What kind of inference is it, then? To call it "experimental" is to beg the question. For all inferences from experience proceed upon the supposition that the future will resemble the past, and that similar powers will be conjoined with similar sensible qualities.

The moment a suspicion arises that the course of nature may change, and that the past may no longer serve as a guide to the future, all experience becomes entirely useless and can support no inference whatever. Therefore, no arguments from experience can prove this resemblance of the past to the future; for all such arguments already presuppose that very resemblance.

However regular the course of things has hitherto been, that alone does not prove that the future will continue to be regular. It is in vain to say, "I have learned the nature of bodies from past experience." For their secret nature, and consequently all their effects, may change without any alteration in their sensible qualities. This happens occasionally with certain objects; why might it not happen with all? What logic, what process of argument secures you against this supposition?

You may say that my practice refutes my doubts; but you must not misunderstand why I raise these questions. As an agent, I am entirely satisfied that the future will resemble the past; but as an inquirer (I will not say sceptic), I wish to know the foundation of this confidence. No reading, no investigation has yet been able to remove this difficulty. Can I do better than

propose the difficulty itself, even if I have no hope of a solution? In this way, though knowledge may not be increased, we will at least become conscious of our ignorance.

My not having been able to find any such reasoning does not justly authorize me to conclude that it really does not exist. Even if learned men should have sought after it for centuries, and failed, it would still be rash to affirm confidently that the subject must surpass all human understanding. Moreover, howsoever we may examine the general sources of our knowledge, and conclude that they are all inadequate, we may still be suspicious that our enumeration is not complete, or our examination not exact. But with regard to the present subject, there are reasons which seem to prove that this conclusion is certain and infallible, and that we are not prone to be caught in a rash presumption.

It is certain that the most ignorant and stupid peasants—nay infants, nay even brute beasts—improve by experience, and learn the qualities of natural objects by observing the effects which result from them. When a child has felt the sensation of pain from touching the flame of a candle, he will be careful not to put his hand near any candle, but will expect a similar effect from a cause which is similar in its sensible qualities and appearance. If you assert that the child makes this inference by any process of argument or ratiocination, you may justly be required to produce that argument, and you have no pretense to refuse so equitable a demand. You cannot say that the argument is abstruse, and may possibly escape your inquiry; since you confess it is obvious to the capacity of a mere infant. If you hesitate a moment, therefore, or if after reflection you produce any intricate or profound argument, you effectively abandon the question; and confess that it is not reasoning which engages us to suppose the past resembling the future, and to expect similar effects from causes which are to appearance similar. This is the proposition which I intended to enforce in the present section.

If I be right, I pretend not to have made any mighty discovery. And if I be wrong, I must acknowledge myself to be a very retrograde scholar; since I cannot now discover an argument which, it seems, was perfectly familiar to me long before I was out of my cradle.

Section 5: Sceptical Solution of these Doubts

Part 1

The passion for philosophy, like that for religion, involves a certain danger. Though it aims at correcting our manners and eradicating our vices, it may, when mismanaged, serve only to encourage us in those tendencies to which we are naturally inclined. While aspiring to wisdom and magnanimity by fixing our contentment on intellectual pleasures rather than bodily ones, we may alienate ourselves from all social virtues and worldly enjoyments, ultimately ending up—like Epictetus and other Stoics—with a philosophy that amounts to nothing more than a refined system of selfishness.

While meditating upon the vanity of human life and the transience of riches, we may only be flattering our own indolence and seeking the support of reason for our reluctance to act in the world. There is, however, one species of philosophy that seems least exposed to this drawback: the sceptical philosophy. Sceptics speak continually of doubt, suspension of judgment, the danger of hasty determinations, confining intellectual inquiries within narrow bounds, and renouncing all speculations that have no bearing on common life. Hence, their

philosophy is directly opposed to the indolence of the mind, its rash arrogance, and superstitious credulity.

This philosophy exerts a subduing influence on every passion except the love of truth, which can never be carried to an excess. It is surprising, therefore, that although almost always harmless and innocent, it should so often be accused of being immoral, profane, or irreligious. Perhaps the very thing that secures its innocence is also the cause of the prejudice against it: because it flatters no irregular passion, it gains few partisans; but because it opposes so many vices and absurdities, it raises up an abundance of enemies.

Nor is there any danger that this philosophy, in seeking to confine our inquiries to common life, should ever undermine the inferences we make in daily practice. Nature will always maintain her rights and prevail over all abstract speculations. In the previous section, I showed that inferences from experience are not founded on reasoning; yet these inferences form the foundation of nearly all the knowledge we possess, and therefore cannot be surrendered. If they do not arise from reason, they must be founded on some other principle of equal force in human nature. It is well worth our while to investigate what this principle is.

Suppose a person endowed with the strongest faculties of reason and reflection were suddenly brought into this world. He would immediately observe a continual succession of objects, and one event following another; but he could discover nothing beyond this. He would not be able, by any process of reasoning, to reach the idea of cause and effect, because:

- (1) The particular powers by which natural operations are performed never appear to the senses; and
- (2) It does not follow that because one event precedes another, they are causally connected. Their conjunction may be purely accidental.

Therefore, such a person could never form any reasoning concerning matters of fact until he had acquired further experience.

Suppose next that this person has gained more experience: he observes similar objects constantly conjoined together. What conclusion does he draw from this experience? He immediately infers the existence of one object from the appearance of the other! Yet all his experience has not given him any knowledge of the secret power, nor has any process of reasoning led him to this inference. Still, he finds himself determined to draw it. There is some other principle that compels him to do so.

This principle is **Custom** or **Habit**.

Where the inclination to act or think in a certain manner is not produced by any reasoning, but solely by our having previously acted or thought in that way, we say that this tendency is the effect of Custom. By using that word, we do not pretend to have given the ultimate reason of the propensity; we merely point to an acknowledged and universal principle of human nature.

Perhaps we can go no further, and cannot assign the cause of this principle; yet it remains the ultimate explanation of the conclusions we draw from experience.

After the constant conjunction of two objects—for instance, heat and flame—custom determines us to expect the one upon the appearance of the other. Indeed, this hypothesis seems the only one that explains why we draw from a thousand instances an inference which we cannot draw from a single instance that is in no way different from them.

Reason is not capable of any such variation: the conclusions it draws from considering one circle are the very same it would reach after examining all the circles in the universe. But no man, having seen only one body move after being struck by another, could infer that every body will move under a similar impulse. All inferences from experience, therefore, are effects of custom, not of reasoning.

Custom, then, is the great guide of human life.

Without it, our experience would be entirely useless; we would never expect the future to resemble the past, nor would we know what means to employ in order to attain our ends. All action would cease, and the greater part of our mental faculties would be extinguished.

I must observe, however, that although inferences from experience carry us beyond our memory and senses, every such inference must necessarily proceed from some fact present to the senses or memory.

If a man finds the ruins of stately buildings in a desert country, he concludes that the land was anciently inhabited by civilized people; but without that initial sensory experience, he could never have drawn such an inference. We learn the events of ancient times from history; yet to do so, we must read historical records and trace the chain of testimony back to the original witnesses of the events. Without some starting fact present to memory or the senses, all our conclusions would be purely hypothetical, with no link in the chain connecting them to real existence.

When I ask why you believe any matter of fact, you must assign another fact as your reason. But this cannot proceed to infinity; you must at last arrive at some fact present to your memory or senses—or else acknowledge that your belief is entirely foundationless.

What, then, is the conclusion of the whole matter? A conclusion very simple, yet widely different from the received theories of philosophy:

All belief in matter of fact or real existence is derived merely from some object present to the memory or senses, and a customary conjunction between that and some other object.

In other words: having found, in many instances, that two kinds of objects—such as flame and heat, snow and cold—have always been conjoined together; if flame or snow be presented anew to the senses, the mind is carried by habit to expect heat or cold.

This belief is the necessary result of placing the mind in such circumstances.

The operation of mind by which we infer these effects is not founded on reasoning; it is a natural instinct, unavoidable just as feeling the passion of love when we receive benefit, or hatred when we meet with injuries.

At this point, it would be reasonable to conclude our philosophical researches; yet if our curiosity prompts us to inquire deeper, we may examine a little further into the nature of this belief and the customary conjunction from which it is derived.

Part 2 (Section 5)

Nothing is more free than the human imagination; and though it is confined to the original stock of ideas furnished by the internal and external senses, it has unlimited power of mixing, compounding, separating, and dividing these ideas. The imagination can invent a series of events with all the appearance of reality, assign them a specific time and place, conceive them as actually existing, and depict them with as much vivid detail as historical facts in which we firmly believe.

What, then, is the difference between such a fiction and belief? It is not this: That some particular idea accompanies every proposition we assent to, and is absent from those that are merely fictional.

This is an incorrect explanation; because...